

Law 401D – Prof Michael Jackson
Alisa Bell (26131953)

This is a poem about the “prison” experienced by victims and prisoners (often one and the same) who engage in a sort of macabre dance of being “imprisoned” by the other, whether in perception, identity, and/ or reality.

The Tunnel

Here, in the tunnel,
Cold, sightless, sleeping,
As in the graves,
As life becomes,
Became,
In time,
Forever and fleeting,
This way

Woken by echoes above,
Where life continues,
Curious – alien – sounds;
Secret squeals,
Muffled speech,
Pitch beyond range,
Words indiscernible,
Dialogue, forming,
Through connections belonging,
To a different world,
Person, time, place,
Above, beyond and beyond,
This dark tunnel space

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Here, in the tunnel,
There is only
Darkness, coldness, echoes of living,
Wailing above,
Where incessant shuffling
Of feet prevail;
Hurried feet,
Slowed feet,
Crippled feet;
This way,
That way,
Like sharks,
They never stop moving

Here in the tunnel,
Bewildered,
Searching,
Trying to comprehend
Sordid life,
Searching

“For what?” I ask, suddenly forgetting.

“Why, you’re searching,” reminds a
Tunnel neighbour,
“For the Ghost
Who stole your soul,”
She says matter of fact.
Indeed,
How could I forget?
How did she know?

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I heard he is faceless,
And lives in these sewers,
I heard he is draped in a dark, protracted cloak,
Woven by a balding midget,
With blank, blinking eyes,
Bright purple lips,
And a copper soul
That bleeds carrotty.

Here, in the tunnel,
Trapped in moments
I wish to outlive,
Here, in moments,
Relived

“He will never face you,”
Another tunnel neighbour whispers,
“Move on, my dear, move on,
Leave the gutter!” she implores

“But feel here!” I say,
“I don’t want to be here!” I beg to be heard
“I want my soul back!
Do you hear?”

Do they hear?

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I listen,
Waiting on every sound,
Weighting every sound,
Until I recognize the pattern
And realize,
“I don’t need him
To see him!
The faceless Ghost,
Lives – I hear him –
Everywhere
And nowhere.”

And the balding midget
Thinks this grand

“They can’t see us,”
She hisses,
Raising her snaky arm,
Clutched to a filthy jar,
Wherein, preserved,
Rest their gouged eyes.

“Give me those!” The
Faceless Ghost demands,
Grabbing the jar,
Swallowing
The bloody eyes down,
Like Jello

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“You moron!” the Midget yells
“Those were our children’s!”

“I know,” says the faceless Ghost,
“I was hungry,” he shrugs
“I am hungry, still,” he declares
“Insatiable,” he shows insight
“You knew this!” he blames the midget

A neighbour in a tunnel hole nearby
Warns her pet rat,
“The faceless Ghost
Is a crooked Alchemist,
He transforms gold into shit!”

“You’re crazy,” I yell.

“Oh?!” the neighbour
Thinking it her pet who spoke,
Raises the rat by its tail,
And drops it, squealing,
Into a smoky cauldron,

“That will teach you not to talk back!”

“You’re crazy!” I yell, again

“Oh!?” the neighbour,
Rat-less,
Realizes her mistake

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“Oh!?” she peeks into the
Smokey cauldron,
Wherein rests her pet’s corpse

Then shifting gears quickly,
She asks, “So you didn’t notice
The art on the walls?”

And I look up

I look up at the walls and see,
Glorious pictures,
Of the world above,
Glorious pictures,
Of the world I once knew,
Glorious pictures,
Painted in feces

I cover my ears,
Eyes shut already,
In the dark tunnel,
Cold, sightless, sleeping,
As in the graves,
Huddled, here,
In hate,
That built these walls;
These maddening, echoing, deafening walls!

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“These are not my walls!” I scream

“These are his walls!” I yell

Like a mad man, pulling at his hair, screaming,

“This is not my head! This is his head!”

Like a mad man,

Longing for prison

END